Eighteen days later, on 2 June 1973, we were back at Sriharikota on a starry night. As the countdown progressed, my heart thumped against my chest, but on the outside, I wore a confident look. My reputation and dream were at stake. LP-006 lifted off majestically, and both the stages performed —in front of our eyes—perfectly. Unlike the previous flight, this one was instrumented and tracked well by the radar which confirmed normal performance of the engine. There was applause.

Modesty escapes me at times of both triumph and tribulation.

'See, now you all agree that the previous launch was also a success; only that we couldn't watch it against the day sky,' I said.

The dispute continues to date, and it is time for me to confess: While my argument about the backlight that blinded us from seeing the second stage burnout still stands, I believe my trained eye could not have missed the brilliant flare from the liquid engine. Yes, privately I had told myself that the first attempt was probably a failure. In the absence of a scientific validation either way—whether it was a success or a failure—I stood my ground then. And for good reason: conceding would have meant a deathblow for the liquid concept, and I was keen on a second attempt.

Now that we had proved the might of our 'Diwali rocket', it was time to dream bigger. While the Russians were using 110-tonne liquid engines, I thought it was not out of place to think of a three-tonne liquid engine. But, with the project yet to be officially recognized as one, we were working with the meagre allocations for R&D. Our first necessity for a three-tonne engine was a ground-test facility. The 600 kg stuff could be tested on the Thumba beach with some rudimentary stand, but a bigger version needed a better facility which would cost some money.

The group that still refused to see merit in the liquid engine tried to put up barricades. Many came up with a variety of reasons to stymie the liquid engine test facility. Some of their points were arguable, many were absurd. Some said it was dangerous to have the facility at Thumba, some others found the very idea of storing liquid propellants an invitation to disaster. Proponents of this risk theory got a shot in the arm when U Subbaiah Pillai, a curious and sincere technician did something foolish: to see if we had